at them, and asked us to finish the lunch quickly so that we could resume the journey.

We reached Ernakulam around 5 pm. The van meandered through narrow roads to the CBI office on the outskirts. By now somehow word had spread about the ISRO spies being taken to Ernakulam, and a crowd had gathered at the CBI office there. Alighting there, we were made to sit on the foyer. Policemen were struggling to stop the surge of onlookers keen on getting a glance of Nambi Narayanan, 'the traitor'.

About fifteen minutes later, we were taken to the court of Chief Judicial Magistrate Ganeswaran Nair. The magistrate asked the same question: Was I ill-treated by the CBI? I replied 'no'.

The magistrate made a note and looked at me with disdain. He remanded us in police custody for fifteen days. The rituals were not over yet; we were taken to a CBI special court in connection with another case that charged Sasikumaran with amassing wealth disproportionate to his known sources of his income. The rest of us, the charge read, had abetted him amass that wealth. CBI special judge Diwakaran remanded us in CBI custody for fifteen days. This second case, I understood later, was to ensure that the ISRO spy case accused remained in jail longer so that the CBI got enough time to question us and complete the investigation.

When we came out of the court, the crowd had swollen and the police had to use mild force to take us to the police van. Soon we were back at the CBI office foyer. We were given tea. I was in a daze, unsure where I would be taken next, when Sasi said to nobody in particular that one of the guards had told him that we would be taken to Delhi.

I asked CBI officer Dhankar what next.

'Wait,' he said. 'You will soon know.'

Around 8.30 pm, dinner was served—chapatti, again. I did not touch it. Around 10.30 pm, a CBI officer told me that the same night we would be taken to Madras as nowhere in Kerala we could be interrogated because the media and the public refused to go away. Soon we were in cars that drove straight to the railway platform, entering the station through a special gate.